

Athena



And Athena pitied her companion and said to her: "It was not I who blinded your child Tiresias. It is not sweet for Athena to steal away the eyes of children. But the laws of Cronus decree thus: Whoever sees any of the immortals, when the god himself does not so choose, let him pay a great price for the seeing."

—CALLIMACHUS, *On the Bath of Athena*, 95–102

The Birth of Athena

The *Homeric Hymn* (28) tells the story of Athena's birth.

I begin to sing about Pallas Athena, renowned goddess, with bright eyes, quick mind, and inflexible heart, chaste and mighty virgin, protectress of the city, Tritogeneia. Wise Zeus himself gave birth to her from his holy head, and she was arrayed in her armor of war, all-gleaming in gold, and every one of the immortals was gripped with awe as they watched. She quickly sprang forth from the immortal head in front of aegis-bearing Zeus, brandishing her sharp spear. And great Olympus shook terribly at the might of the bright-eyed goddess, and the earth round about gave a dread groan and the dark waves of the deep seethed. But suddenly the sea became calm, and the glorious son of Hyperion halted his swift-footed horses all the while that the maiden Pallas Athena took the divine armor from her immortal shoulders, and Zeus in his wisdom rejoiced.

So hail to you, child of aegis-bearing Zeus; yet I shall remember both you and another song too. (17–18)

Hesiod (*Theogony* 886–898) tells how Zeus had swallowed his consort **Metis** (her name means “wisdom”) after he had made her pregnant with Athena; he was afraid that Metis would bear a son who would overthrow him.

Zeus, king of the gods, first took as his wife Metis, who was very wise indeed among both gods and mortals. But when she was about to give birth to the bright-eyed goddess Athena, then Zeus treacherously deceived her with wheedling words and swallowed her down into his belly at the wise instigations of Gaea and starry Uranus. These two gave Zeus this advice so that no other of the eternal gods might rule supreme as king in his place. For Metis was destined to bear exceptional children: first, the keen-eyed maiden Athena, Tritogeneia, the equal of her father in might and good counsel, and then she was to give birth to a son of indomitable spirit who would become the king of both gods and mortals. (886–898)

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Variations in the story of Athena’s birth have Hephaestus split Zeus’ head open with an ax to facilitate the birth. Sometimes Prometheus or even Hermes is a helper. Some add to the dread awe of the occasion by having Athena cry out thunderously as she springs to life in full battle dress. This myth (whatever its etiology in terms of the physical manifestations of the thunderstorm) establishes the close bond between Zeus and his favorite daughter and allegorizes the three basic characteristics of the goddess Athena: her prowess, her wisdom, and the masculinity of her virgin nature sprung ultimately not from the female, but from the male.

The Sculpture of the Parthenon

The Parthenon was the great temple to **Athena Parthenos** (*parthenos*, meaning “virgin,” was a standard epithet of Athena) on the Acropolis at Athens. It was built between 447 and 438 B.C. and embodied the triumph of Greek (and specifically Athenian) courage and piety over the Persians, who had sacked the Acropolis in 480 and destroyed the Old Parthenon. Like the temple of Zeus at Olympia (described on pp. 118–121), the Parthenon was decorated with a complex program of sculpture in which mythology and religion glorified the city and its gods, above all honoring Athena, whose great statue was housed in the temple. The whole program was directed by **Pheidias**, creator of the statue of Zeus at Olympia.

The **east pediment** of the Parthenon immortalized the dramatic moment of the birth of Athena, who stood in the center before the throne of Zeus, from whose head she had just sprung full grown and fully armed. Hephaestus, who had assisted in the birth, and Hera were probably present, while the announcement of the birth was brought to other divine figures waiting to observe the miracle. At the corners, to set the divine event in cosmic time, were the horses of Helios, rising from the sea, and of Selene, sinking into it.

As at Olympia, the **west pediment** was a scene of violent action, celebrating the victory of Athena in her contest with Poseidon for control of Athens and Attica. The central figures pull away from each other as they produce the



The Birth of Athena. Athenian black-figure amphora, sixth century B.C.; height 15 ½ in. Athena emerges fully armed from the head of Zeus, who is seated on his throne holding the thunderbolt. At the left stand Hermes and Apollo (with his kithara), and to the right are Eileithyia, gesturing toward the newborn goddess whose birth she has assisted, and Ares. Beneath the throne is a sphinx. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)

gifts with which they vied, and to each side were figures of divinities and heroic kings of early Athens who attended the contest. Athena with her spear created an olive tree; Poseidon with his trident, a salt spring. Athena was proclaimed victor.

Variants are that Poseidon produced the first horse; Athena may plant an olive tree or, more dramatically, as on this pediment, bring one forth by the touch of her spear. The contest took place on the Acropolis with Athena judged the victor by the gods, or the Athenians, or their king Cecrops. The importance of the olive in Athenian life is symbolized by Athena's victory. Angry at losing, Poseidon flooded the Thriasian plain, but he was appeased. The Athenians were seafarers and Poseidon remained important to them. Poseidon continued to be worshiped (in conjunction with the Athenian hero Erechtheus) in the nearby sanctuary of the **Erechtheum** (described on p. 583). There the marks of Poseidon's trident were enshrined and Athena's olive tree continued to grow.

There were two friezes on the Parthenon. The first, the exterior **Doric frieze**, consisted of ninety-two **metopes** (each 40 inches high), thirty-two on each of the long sides and fourteen on the short ones. On the south were reliefs of the battle of the Lapiths and centaurs, also the subject of the west pediment of the temple of Zeus at Olympia (see p. 119). On the north side the subject was probably the sack of Troy, while on the east it was the Gigantomachy (the battle of the Olympian gods against the giants), and on the west the battle of the Greeks and the Amazons. Thus, the mythical themes of the metopes reinforced the idea of the triumph of Greek courage over the barbarians and of the Greek gods over their predecessors.

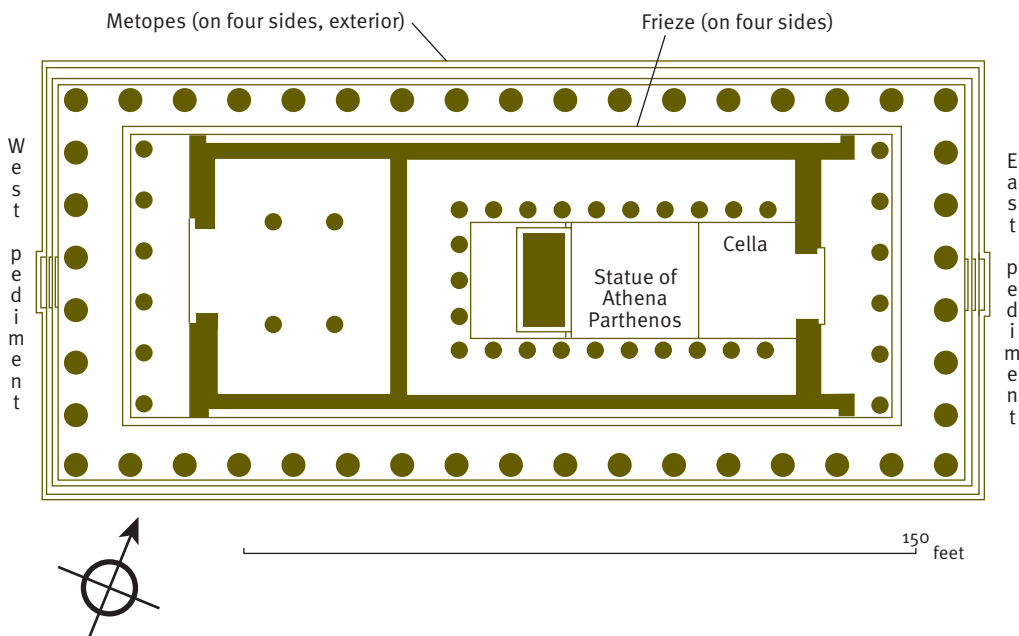


Figure 8.1. Plan of the Parthenon (after J. Travlos)

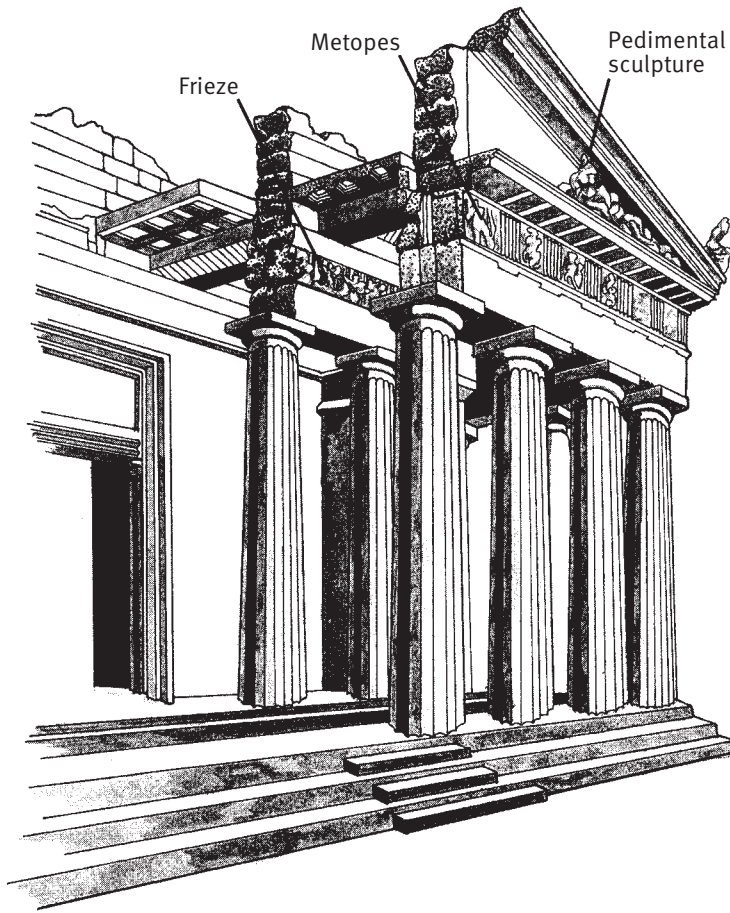


Figure 8.2. Sectional Drawing of the East End of the Parthenon Showing Relationship of Frieze, Metopes, and Pediment (after N. Yalouris)

The second, an **Ionic frieze**, ran continuously round the outer wall of the cella, or naos (the interior part of the temple that housed the statue of Athena and the treasury). It has been generally thought (at least since the eighteenth century) that this frieze shows the people of Athens moving in procession as they celebrate the festival of the **Panathenaea** in honor of their goddess. Athenian men and women are shown as marshals, attendants, horsemen, hoplites, and assistants in the worship of Athena, along with the animals for the ritual sacrifice. Games and contests (not on the frieze) were a part of the festivities; the prize awarded was an amphora filled with oil. On it was depicted Athena in her war gear, with an inscription identifying the vase as Panathenaic. At the climax of the procession, on the east side (i.e., over the entrance to the part of the cella housing the statue), the ceremonial robe (*peplos*) was presented to the priestess of Athena. Nearby sat the Olympian immortals enthroned, taking part in the joyous celebration of civic piety. Some parts of the friezes are still in situ, but the major fragments of the pediments and

the friezes are in the British Museum in London and are known as the Elgin marbles. The *peplos* was dedicated to the ancient wooden statue of Athena Polias (i.e., “guardian of the city”) in the nearby sanctuary of Erechtheus. The old temple was destroyed by the Persians, and the new Erechtheum was completed some thirty years after the Parthenon. For its religious significance, see Chapter 23, pp. 583–585.

Athena Parthenos

In the **cella** of the Parthenon stood a monumental statue, the Athena Parthenos. The original by Pheidias is completely lost, but reconstructions (like the one illustrated on p. 182) may be made with some accuracy.¹ Like Pheidias’ later masterpiece at Olympia, the surfaces of the statue were made of gold and ivory, and its decoration, elaborating the themes of the architectural sculptures already described, gave witness to the honor and glory of the goddess and the city she protected. It was nearly 12 meters high, and in front of it was a reflecting pool. The standing goddess held a figure of Nike (Victory) in her right hand, and her armor included a helmet decorated with sphinxes, the **aegis** with the head of Medusa, a shield, and a spear, beside which was a serpent (representing the chthonic divinity Erechtheus). The shield was decorated with the battle of the Amazons on the exterior, and the Gigantomachy on the interior; on the rims of her sandals were reliefs of the battle with centaurs (all themes repeated from the metopes). The relief on the base of the statue showed the creation of Pandora. In the sculpture of the Parthenon, mythology and religion combine with local pride to glorify the gods and civilization of the Greeks and to celebrate the city and its citizens under the protection of Athena.²

Pallas Athena Tritogeneia

Athena’s title, Tritogeneia, is obscure. It seems to refer to a region sometimes associated with her birth, the river or lake Triton, or Tritonis, in Boeotia or in Libya. Some scholars see in this link the possibility that Athena was, at least in her origins, at one time a goddess of waters or of the sea. We are told that soon after her birth Athena was reared by **Triton** (presumably the god of this body of water, wherever it may be). Now Triton had a daughter named Pallas, and Athena and the girl used to practice the arts of war together. But on one occasion they quarreled and, as Pallas was about to strike Athena, Zeus intervened on behalf of his daughter by interposing the aegis. Pallas was startled, and Athena took advantage of her surprise and wounded and killed her. Athena was distraught when she realized what she had done; in her grief she made a wooden image of the girl and decked it with the aegis. Cast down by Zeus, this statue, called the **Palladium**, fell into the territory of the Trojans, who built a temple to house it in honor. The Palladium in saga carries with it the destiny of the city of Troy. In honor of her friend, Athena took the name Pallas for herself. A more likely etiology is that the word Pallas means maiden and is but another designation of Athena’s chastity, just as she is called Parthenos (Virgin), or (like Persephone) Kore (Girl).

Athena and Arachne

The famous story of Arachne bears testimony to the importance of Athena as the patroness of women's household arts, especially spinning and weaving. In Ovid's account (*Metamorphoses* 6. 5–145) Athena has, of course, become the Roman **Minerva**.

Minerva turned her mind to Arachne's destruction, for she had heard that her fame as a worker in wool equaled her own. Arachne's birth and position brought her no distinction—it was her skill that did. Idmon of Colophon was her father, who dyed the thirsty wool with Ionian purple; her mother, who also was of low birth like her husband, had died. Yet their daughter, Arachne, for all that she was born in a lowly family living at lowly Hypaepa, pursued her quest for fame throughout the cities of Lydia by her work. (5–13)

The nymphs of Tmolus often left their vineyards, the nymphs of Pactolus often left their waters—to see and wonder at Arachne's handiwork. Nor was



Audio



Closer Look



Las Hilanderas (The Weavers), by Diego Velázquez (1599–1660); oil on canvas, ca. 1657; 66 ½ × 98 in. (as shown); enlarged in the eighteenth century to 87 × 114 in. In the foreground tapestry weavers are at work, with an older woman to the left and a young one to the right as the principal figures. In the background, women view the completed tapestry, in which the helmeted Athena is about to strike Arachne with her shuttle, in anger at her subject, *The Rape of Europa*. Velázquez has thus included a reference to Titian's *Rape of Europa* (see p. 413). (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)

Athena Parthenos and Pallas Athena

When, in 480 B.C., the Persians crushed the Greek forces holding the pass at Thermopylae, the Great King Darius, with his enormous host, marched without impediment toward Athens. When they arrived, they invaded the city and ravaged it, including its most holy sanctuaries on the Acropolis. In 479 B.C., the Greeks remarkably were able to defeat the Persian fleet at Salamis and the Persian host at Plataea.

In the years after the Persian Wars, Athens became a naval empire and one of the most powerful states of the Greek world under the leadership of her magnetic general and statesman Pericles (ca. 495–429 B.C.). By the middle of the fifth century, Pericles had decided to inaugurate an immense building program that would reflect the increased stature of the city and pay homage to Athena, their patron goddess, for the blessings she had bestowed upon her favored city. Among the projects that resulted from this vast expenditure of funds was the Parthenon. The Greek sculptor Pheidias was commissioned to supervise the work, which was brought to completion between 447 and 438 B.C. He himself produced the chryselephantine (gold and ivory) statue of *Athena Parthenos* that graced the cella of the temple. Gold and ivory seem to have been Pheidias' favored media; he used the same materials for his masterpiece, the statue of Zeus at Olympia.

The *Athena Parthenos* was built around a wooden frame or core and stood almost 40 feet tall. It required more than a ton of gold sheathing. The statue has long since been lost, but a general idea of the conception of the artist and the composition of the figure is preserved through ancient literary sources, like Pausanias, and Roman copies, which do not approach the genius and beauty of the original. Pheidias was a monumental sculptor, and the qualities most admired in the ancient world were the grandeur and beauty of his figures. His *Athena Parthenos* was majestic and awe-inspiring. It was the epitome of the high classical style. Together with the other sculptural decorations on the Parthenon, it expressed the Athenian sense that the Persian Wars, like their mythic analogues, illustrated the triumph of Greek civilization over barbarism.

The Austrian painter Gustave Klimt (1862–1918) was one of the most prominent artists and intellectuals at the forefront of an extraordinary cultural efflorescence in Vienna at the end of the nineteenth and the beginning of the twentieth centuries. During this period, Sigmund Freud and Carl Jung were exposing the darker, sublimated forces at work in the unconscious mind. The German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, whose work explored, as he saw it, the opposition of the Apollonian and Dionysian forces in Greek culture, had a



Athena Parthenos. Reconstruction by N. Leipen of the original by Pheidias, 447–438 B.C.; about one-tenth full size. The original cult-statue stood some 38 feet tall, its gold and ivory gleaming in the half-light as the worshiper entered the cella with its double row of columns and reflecting pool. Pheidias focused on the majesty of the city's goddess, and the reliefs on her shield, sandals, and statue-base all are symbols of the victory of order over disorder in the human and divine spheres. The atmosphere of civic grandeur is far from the intimate emotion of the *Mourning Athena* on page 186. (With permission of the Royal Ontario Museum © ROM)

profound influence on the intellectual culture of Vienna at the time. For Nietzsche, Greek tragedy, as it developed in the Archaic Age of the sixth century B.C., touched upon the transcendent, liberating spirit of the Dionysian. These Viennese intellectuals, influenced by Nietzsche, rejected the canons of an earlier generation, marred as they were by an unemotional restraint that produced art that was devoid of spirit, passion, and energy.

Klimt, for his part, was a member of a circle of artists who championed the Vienna Secession, a movement that sought to free artistic expression from what they saw as the sterile and lifeless art of the previous generation. The inaugural exhibition for the Secession artists was held in 1898 and included Klimt's *Pallas Athena*. In a real sense, Klimt's vision of Athena became an icon for the Secession movement. His *Pallas Athena* is a remarkably complex and multi-layered work. While Klimt, who was a goldsmith, seems to evoke the image of Pheidias' *Athena Parthenos* in the gold-laden head and torso of his Athena and the contrasting white of her face and arm, his work is not an homage. Rather, it bespeaks the illusion of surface and the disquieting depths beneath that surface. Elements of the image belong more properly to the archaic sixth century B.C., not the classical fifth century B.C.: the gorgoneion on her aegis is of an earlier type; her helmet is not the resplendent, ceremonial headdress of Pheidias' image (which allows the viewer to see Athena's whole face), but an earlier Corinthian helmet, which masks the features of the goddess; in the background, Klimt has reproduced a sixth-century B.C. vase depicting Heracles wrestling Triton, who in myth is associated with Athena. The most unsettling features of the image are Athena's eyes; it has been suggested that Klimt was influenced by the Homeric epithet *glaukopis* (see p. 187). Eye motifs are prevalent throughout the entire work, appearing on the circular tassels of her shield, the almost owl-like design on the body of Triton, and even in the decoration on the frame. In fact, Athena's eyes seem to have assumed the terrifying power of the Gorgon; her full-frontal gaze is an assault and a challenge to look upon her and be defeated. Though Klimt's depiction of Athena is very different from his other, more typically erotic *femmes fatales*, an eroticism is channeled into the nude, sexually charged, and triumphant image of Victory that Athena holds.



Pallas Athena, by Gustav Klimt (1862–1918); oil on canvas, 29½ × 29½ in. Klimt focuses on the latent energy of the warrior goddess, while giving a new interpretation to her traditional attributes of helmet, gray eyes, owl, Gorgon and aegis, spear, and Nike (who is painted as a naked woman with red hair). The gold highlights (Klimt was the son of a gold engraver) again reinterpret the gold and ivory of Pheidias' statue. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look



Athena. Detail from an Attic red-figure amphora on p. 572. In the center of the vase, Heracles and Apollo struggle for possession of the Delphic tripod. Athena, standing behind Heracles, appears in typical battle dress, wearing a helmet with a prominent crest and holding a spear and shield. She wears an elaborate aegis fringed with snake tassels with a large *gorgoneion*, a stylized depiction of the gorgon's head with feral grin and darting tongue. (*Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY*)

their pleasure merely in seeing her finished work, but also in observing her at work, such delight was in her skill. Whether at the beginning she gathered the unworked wool into balls, or worked it with her fingers and drew out lengths of fleece like clouds, or with swift-moving thumb turned the smooth spindle, or whether she used her embroidering needle—you would know that Minerva had taught her. Yet she would not admit this; jealous of her great teacher, she said, “Let her compete with me; if she wins I deny her nothing.” (14–25)

Minerva disguised herself as an old woman, white-haired and supporting herself upon a stick, and spoke as follows: “Not everything that old age brings is to be avoided; experience comes with the passing years. Do not despise my advice! Let your ambition be to excel mortal women at weaving; give place to the goddess and pray for her forgiveness for your rash words! She will pardon you if you pray.” Arachne glowered at her; leaving her half-finished work and with difficulty restraining herself from blows, she openly showed her anger by her expression, as she attacked disguised Minerva with these words: “You old fool, enfeebled by advanced old age. Too long a life has done you no good! Keep your advice for your sons’ wives (if you have any) and your daughter. I can think for myself, and you need not think your advice does any good—you will not change my mind. Why does not the goddess herself come? Why does she refuse to compete with me?” (26–42)

Then Minerva cried: “She has come!” and throwing off her disguise she showed herself as she was, the goddess Minerva. The nymphs and women of Lydia worshiped her divine presence; Arachne alone felt no awe. Yet she blushed; a sudden flush stole over her face in spite of herself and as suddenly faded, like the red glow of the sky when Dawn first glows just before the heavens begin to whiten with the sun’s rising. Obstinate she held to her course and rushed to destruction in her foolish desire for the prize. Jupiter’s daughter resisted no more; she offered her no more advice; no more did she put off the competition. (43–52)

Ovid goes on to describe the weaving contest. Each weaves a tapestry at her loom with surpassing skill, depicting scenes from mythology. Minerva displays her contest with Neptune for the lordship of Attica and adds four subordinate scenes of mortals who challenged gods and were turned by them into other shapes. The whole was framed by an olive tree motif: “with her own tree she concluded her work.”

Heedless of the lessons of Minerva’s legends, Arachne depicted scenes of the gods’ less honorable amorous conquests—where Jupiter, Neptune, Apollo, Bacchus, and Saturn deceived goddesses and mortal women. As she completed her tapestry with a design of trailing ivy, Minerva’s anger burst forth. Ovid continues:

Minerva could find no fault with the work, not even Envy herself could. Angered by Arachne’s success, the golden-haired goddess tore up the

embroidered tapestry with its stories of the gods' shameful deeds. With the boxwood shuttle she beat Arachne's face repeatedly. In grief Arachne strangled herself, stopping the passage of life with a noose. Minerva pitied her as she was hanging and raised her up with these words: "Stubborn girl, live, yet hang! And—to make you anxious for the future—may the same punishment be decreed for all your descendants." (129–138)

With these words Minerva sprinkled her with the juice of a magic herb. As the fateful liquid touched her, Arachne's hair dropped off; her nose and ears vanished, and her head was shrunken; her whole body was contracted. From her side thin fingers dangled for legs, and the rest became her belly. Yet still from this she lets the thread issue forth and, a spider now, practices her former weaving art. (139–145)

This story illustrates the severe, moral earnestness of this warrior maiden that is often only too apparent. Yet, as Ovid tells it, Minerva's punishment of Arachne's hubris is also motivated by jealousy of her success.

The Character and Appearance of Athena

A study of women, cloth, and society in early times presents insights into how women's textile arts function as analogy and metaphor in mythology and illuminates the importance of Athena as the goddess of the "central womanly skill of weaving."³ Athena represented not only skill but also cunning, and so weaving became a metaphor for human resourcefulness, as illustrated by clever Penelope, a wily wife, just like her wily husband Odysseus. The concept of life as a thread created by women and controlled by the feminine fates presents a major related theme. Weaving, however necessary, was also revered as a most respected art that belonged to the *arete* (excellence) of a woman as opposed to the different *arete* of a man.

Athena is a goddess of many other specific arts, crafts, and skills (military, political, and domestic), as well as the deification of wisdom and good counsel in a more generic and abstract conception. She is skilled in the taming and training of horses, interested in ships and chariots, and the inventor of the flute. This invention was supposedly inspired by the lamentations (accompanied by the hiss of serpents) uttered by the surviving Gorgons after the death of Medusa. But Athena quickly grew to dislike the new instrument because her beautiful features became distorted when she played, and so she threw it away in disgust. Marsyas, the satyr, picked up the instrument with dire consequences, as we shall see in Chapter 11. In Athens, Athena was worshiped along with Hephaestus as patroness of all arts and crafts.

Athena is often represented in art with her attributes as a war goddess: helmet, spear, and shield (the aegis, on which the head of the Gorgon Medusa may be depicted). Sometimes she is attended by a winged figure (Nike, Victory) bearing a crown or garland of honor and success. Athena herself, as **Athena**



Athena and Heracles. Interior of a kylix by the potter Python and painter Duris, ca. 475 B.C.; diameter 13 in. On the viewer's left Heracles sits on a rock, wearing his lionskin and with his club resting beside him. He is refreshed by Athena, who stands opposite and pours wine from an oinochoe (a jug for wine) into a two-handled kylix. She wears the aegis (note the four snakes on the lower right) and holds an owl in her left hand: her spear is held at rest, and her helmet rests on a plinth. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)



Audio

Mourning Athena. Marble relief from the Acropolis, ca. 460 B.C.; height 21 in. Athena is a young woman, with helmet and spear, but without aegis and shield. She gazes at a stele (an upright stone slab) on which may have been inscribed the names of Athenians killed in the previous year's fighting. The folds of her skirt follow her body and do not fall straight. The title and purpose of the work are unknown, but it shows how closely the goddess was concerned with the life and death of her citizens. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)



Nike, represented victorious achievement in war, and a simple but elegant temple of Athena Nike stood on a bastion to the right of the entrance to the Acropolis. The brief *Homeric Hymn to Athena* (11) invokes her as a deity of war (like Ares).

I begin to sing about Pallas Athena, city-guardian, who with Ares is concerned about the deeds of war—the din of fighting and battles and the sacking of cities; she also protects the people as they leave and return. Hail, goddess, give us good luck and good fortune. (1–5)

Pallas Athena is beautiful, with a severe and aloof kind of loveliness that is masculine and striking. One of her standard epithets is *glaukopis*, which may mean gray- or green-eyed, but more probably refers to the bright or keen radiance of her glance rather than to the color of her eyes. Possibly, too, the adjective may be intended to mean owl-eyed, or of owl-like aspect or countenance; certainly, Athena is at times closely identified with the owl (particularly on coins). The snake is also associated with her, sometimes appearing coiled at her feet or on her shield. This association (along with those of the owl and the olive tree) suggests that perhaps Athena originally was (like so many others) a fertility goddess, even though her character as a virgin dominates later tradition.

In fact, her character is usually impeccable. Unlike another virgin goddess, Artemis, to whom men made advances (although at their dire peril), Athena remained sexually unapproachable. Hephaestus' attempt on her honor (in the early saga of Athens, p. 582) confirms the purity and integrity of her convictions. It would be a misconception, however, to imagine Athena only as a cold and formidable virago who might easily elicit one's respect but hardly one's love. This Valkyrie-like maiden does have her touching moments, not only in her close and warm relationship with her father, Zeus, but also in her devout loyalty and steadfast protection of more than one hero (e.g., Telemachus and Odysseus, Heracles, Perseus, Jason, and Bellerophon).

Either alone or coupled with Apollo, Athena can be made the representative of a new order of divinity—the younger generation of the gods championing progress and the advanced enlightenment of civilization. As the agent of Zeus, Athena brings the *Odyssey* to a close by answering the primitive demand for blood evoked by the relatives of the suitors and establishing the divine and universal validity of the justice meted out by Odysseus. In Aeschylus' *Oresteia* she is on the side of Apollo for the acquittal of Orestes through the due process of law in Athens before the court of the Areopagus (which the goddess is said to have created), appeasing and silencing, presumably forever, the old social order of family vendetta represented by the Furies.

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Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 1.24.5–1.24.7: Sculpture of the Parthenon

Notes

1. There are a number of ancient, miniature replicas and a description by Pausanias (1. 24). Copyright permission cannot be obtained to reproduce the most recent full-scale reconstruction in the Parthenon at Nashville, Tennessee.
2. For the Parthenon and its sculpture, see John Travlos, *Pictorial Dictionary of Ancient Athens* (New York: Praeger, 1971), entry for “Parthenon”; Martin Robertson and Alison

Frantz, *The Parthenon Frieze* (New York: Phaidon), distinguished by Frantz's photography; John Boardman, *Greek Sculpture: The Classical Period* (London: Thames and Hudson, 1955), Chapter 10, "The Parthenon," pp. 96–145, includes diagrams, reconstructions, and photographs in his useful, short account; Martin Robertson, *A Shorter History of Greek Art* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1981), pp. 90–102, for the Parthenon, the best discussion, distilled from the author's *A History of Greek Art*, 2 vols. (1975), Chapter 5, pp. 292–322.

3. Elisabeth Wayland Barber, *Women's Work: The First 20,000 Years* (New York: Norton, 1994), p. 242.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Aphrodite and Eros



The Babylonians have a most disgraceful custom: a native woman once in her life must sit in the sanctuary of Aphrodite and have sex with a stranger. . . . Those possessed of beauty and stature are quickly released, but those who are unattractive remain for quite a while, since they are unable to fulfill the law. Some wait three or four years.

—HERODOTUS, *History of the Persian Wars* 1.199.1–5

AS WE HAVE SEEN, Hesiod describes the birth of Aphrodite after the castration of Uranus and derives her name from the Greek word *aphros* (foam). Hesiod also links the goddess closely with Cythera (see p. 71) and with Cyprus; the latter was especially associated with her worship, particularly in its city of Paphos. Thus, Aphrodite is called both Cytherea and Cypris. Another version of her birth gives her parents as Zeus and Dione. Dione is little more than a name to us, but a curious one, since it is the feminine form of the name Zeus (which in another form is Dios).

Aphrodite Urania and Aphrodite Pandemos

This double tradition of Aphrodite's birth suggests a basic duality in her character or the existence of two separate goddesses of love: Aphrodite Urania or Celestial Aphrodite, sprung from Uranus alone, is ethereal and sublime; Aphrodite Pandemos (Aphrodite of All the People, or Common Aphrodite), sprung from Zeus and Dione, is essentially physical in nature. Plato's *Symposium* elaborates on this distinction and claims that Aphrodite Urania, the older of the two, is stronger, more intelligent, and spiritual, whereas Aphrodite Pandemos, born from both sexes, is more base and devoted primarily to physical satisfaction.¹ It is imperative to understand that the Aphrodite who sprang from Uranus